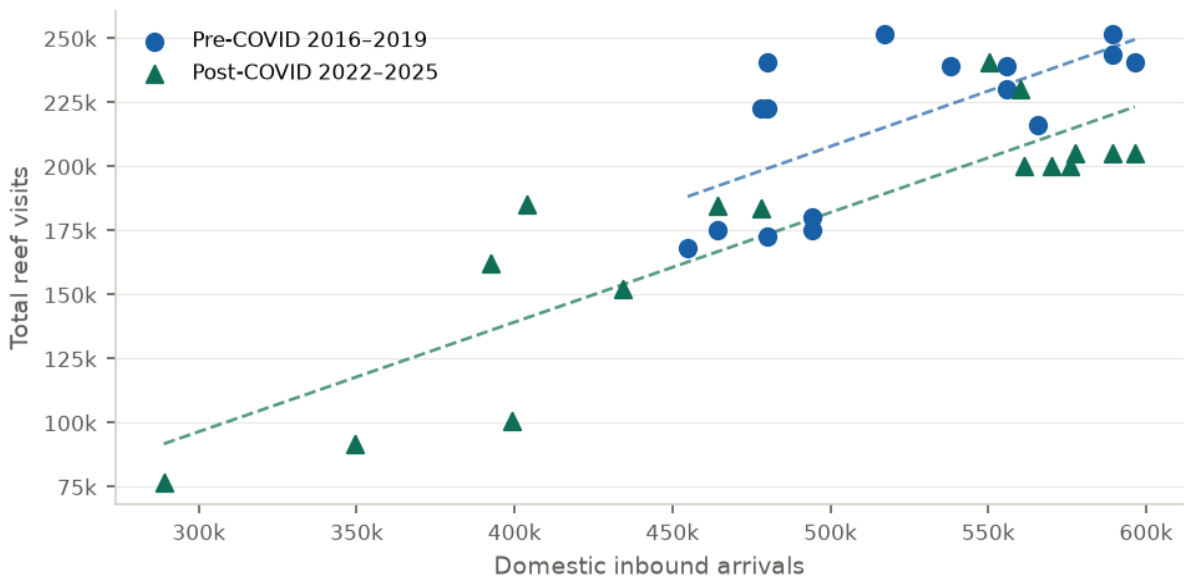


What drives reef visitation in Cairns?

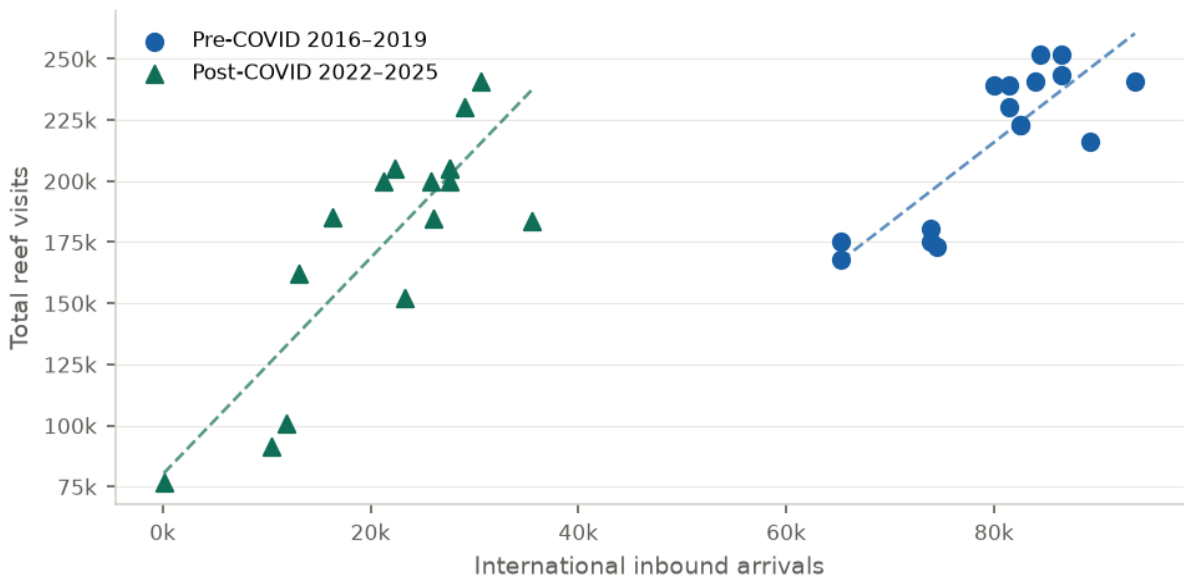
How closely do airport arrivals predict reef trips? — Cairns, 2016–2025 (excl. 2020–2021 COVID disruption)

Period	Strongest predictor of reef trips	Strength of relationship	How much variation explained	Quarters analysed
Pre-COVID 2016–2019	International arrivals	Strong ($r=0.69$)	48%	16
Post-COVID 2022–2025	Domestic arrivals	Very strong ($r=0.86$)	74%	16

Domestic inbound arrivals vs total reef visits



International inbound arrivals vs total reef visits



Key findings

International visitors drive reef demand — but that market is still recovering

Before COVID, international arrivals were a stronger predictor of reef trips than domestic arrivals ($r=0.69$ vs 0.62). This suggests international tourists are more likely to visit the reef when they come to Cairns. However, international passenger numbers collapsed during COVID and have been rebuilding unevenly since — making this relationship harder to measure in the post-COVID period.

Domestic visitors are now the reef's most reliable indicator

Post-COVID, domestic arrivals have become the strongest single predictor of reef demand ($r=0.86$, explaining 74% of variation). This reflects the faster recovery of the domestic market and means reef operators are heavily reliant on domestic airline capacity into Cairns.

The reef is more tied to the airport than it used to be

Pre-COVID, airport arrivals explained around half of reef visit variation — other factors like weather, marketing, and tour operator capacity played a significant role. Post-COVID, that figure has risen to 75%. Reef tourism is now more directly tied to what happens at the airport, making it more vulnerable to airline route changes or anything that suppresses visitor numbers to Cairns.

Data sources: EMC Cairns quarterly reef visitation data; Cairns Airport monthly passenger statistics. Analysis excludes 2020 (full COVID disruption) and 2021 (transitional recovery year).